

Chapter 17

The User Roles

Over the course of the next five chapters we will undertake a small, hypothetical project. In this chapter we'll start by identifying the key user roles. In subsequent chapters we'll move on to writing stories, estimating the stories, planning a release, and writing acceptance tests for the stories in the release.

The Project

Our company, South Coast Nautical Supplies, has been selling sailing supplies through a print catalog for thirty years. Our catalogs feature items such as Global Positioning Systems, clocks, weather equipment, navigation and plotting equipment, life rafts, inflatable vests, charts, maps and books. So far our Internet presence has been a simple one-page site directing people to call a toll-free number to request a catalog.

Our boss has decided we should finally get with the times and start selling things over the Internet. However, rather than start by selling some of our bigger ticket items, he wants us to start by selling just books. Some items in our catalog cost over \$10,000 and until we know our site works well and doesn't lose orders, we don't want to take any risk with expensive items. But if we find that our customers like being able to order online, and if we do a good job on the site, we'll expand and sell the rest of our products on the site.

Oh, and the last thing the boss says is that the site needs to be live in thirty days so we can capture increased sales during the peak summer sailing months.

Identifying the Customer

The project needs a customer to help us identify and write stories. The customers for this product are the sailors who buy the books and they are all outside

the company. So, we need an internal customer who can act as a proxy for the real end-user customers. For this the boss designates Lori, who is the vice president of Sales and Marketing.

In an initial meeting with Lori she provides more background on the system she needs. She wants a “typical bookstore/eCommerce site.” She wants customers to be able to search for books in a variety of ways (we don’t push for clarification at this point), she wants users to be able to maintain lists of books they’ll buy later, she wants users to rate and review books they buy, and she wants to them users check on the status of an order. We’ve seen plenty of sites like this so we tell Lori we’re ready to start.

Identifying Some Initial Roles

The first thing we do is gather some of the developers together with Lori in a room with a large table. Lori has already researched the market and knows the demographics of our typical customers. Lori and the developers write the following user role cards, which are placed as shown in Figure 17.1:

- Hardcore Sailor
- Novice Sailor
- New Sailor
- Gift-Buyer
- Non-Sailing Spouse
- Administrator
- Sales Vice President
- Charter Captain
- Experienced Sailor
- Sailing School
- Library
- Instructor

Consolidating and Narrowing

After the user role names are written on cards we need to remove duplicates or near duplicates, consider whether any roles should be merged, and come up with a refined list of user roles that the project will start with. The easiest way to start is by trying to remove any card that is placed entirely on top of another card, indicating that its author thought they were duplicates.

In this case, the New Sailor card has been placed on top of the Novice Sailor card. The authors of those cards explain what they intended by them, and anyone else adds any remarks they wish. It turns out that there is a distinction between a Novice Sailor and a New Sailor. A New Sailor is someone who is new to the sport of sailing; perhaps she is currently taking lessons or has sailed a few times. The author of the Novice Sailor card actually meant that role to represent someone who may have been sailing for years but just not often enough to have become good at it. The group decides that although these roles appear to be slightly different, they are not sufficiently different that it is worth having two roles for them. They are merged together in a single role, Novice Sailor, and the New Sailor card is torn up and thrown away.

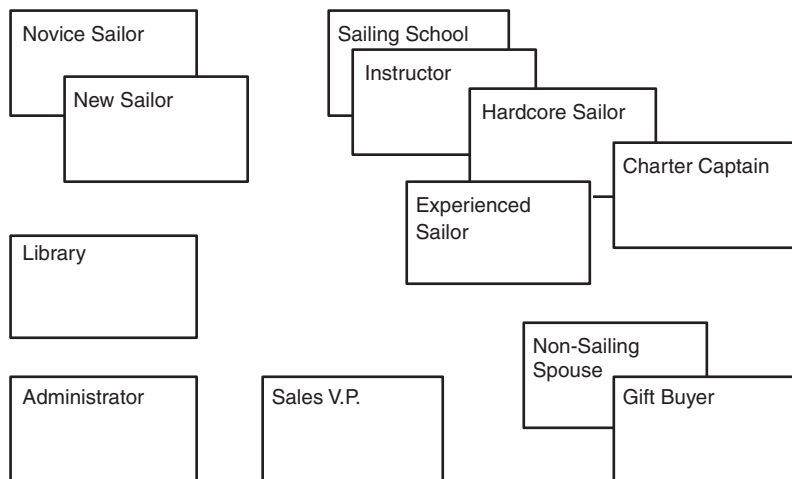


Figure 17.1 Positioning the user role cards.

Next, the group considers the overlapping Sailing School and Instructor cards. The author of the Instructor card explains that the role represents sailors who teach sailing classes. Instructors, she argues, frequently buy copies of books for their students or perhaps assemble lists of books that students are

required to read. The author of the Sailing School role card indicates that this is partially what she intended for that card. However, she thought that typical use would be by an administrator at the school rather than by the sailing instructor himself. Lori the customer clears this up for us by telling us that even if it is a school administrator, the administrator will have many of the same characteristics of an Instructor. Since an Instructor is more clearly a single person than is Sailing School, the Sailing School card is torn up.

The Hardcore Sailor card has been postioned so that it partially overlaps Instructor, Experienced Sailor and even the Charter Captain role cards. The group discusses these roles next and learns that the Hardcore Sailor role was written to capture the type of sailor who typically knows exactly which books she wants. The Hardcore Sailor knows, for example, the name of the best book on navigation. Her search patterns will therefore be quite different from those of a less knowledgeable sailor, even an Experienced Sailor. The Experienced Sailor role represents people very familiar with the products the site will offer but who may not automatically recall the names of the best books.

After discussing Charter Captain, the team decides that role is essentially the same as Hardcore Sailor and the card is torn up.

At this point, the team has decided to keep Novice Sailor, Instructor, Hardcore Sailor, and Experienced Sailor. They've disposed of New Sailor, Charter Captain, and Sailing School. And they have yet to consider Gift-Buyer, Non-Sailing Spouse, Administrator, and Sales Vice President. The authors of these remaining role cards explain their intent.

The Gift Buyer role represents someone who is not a sailor but who is buying a gift for someone who is. The author of the Non-Sailing Spouse role indicates that this was the intent behind that card. After some discussion about the two role cards the team decides to tear both up and replace them with a consolidated card for the Non-Sailing Gift Buyer role.

The author of the Administrator role explains that this role represents the work that will be done by one or more administrators who will need to load data into the system and otherwise keep the system running. This is the first role the team talks about that represents someone who is not buying items from the site. After discussing it, they decide that the role is important, and Lori indicates that she will have some stories about how the system will be maintained and how new items will be added to the site's inventory.

The Sales Vice President role is discussed next. This is another non-purchasing role. However, the CEO has mandated that the new system be watched very closely to see how it is affecting sales. The team considers leaving the role out because they don't think there will be many stories specifically for the role. In

the end they decide to include the role but to rename it to the more generic Report Viewer.

The Library role is discussed. For a moment the team thinks it might be similar to either a Sailing School or even a Non-Sailing Spouse. However, the group rejects these ideas and decides to keep Library as a role. However, in keeping with the guideline to create roles that represent discrete users, the Library card is ripped up and replaced with a Librarian card.

At this point the team has settled on the roles shown in Figure 17.2.

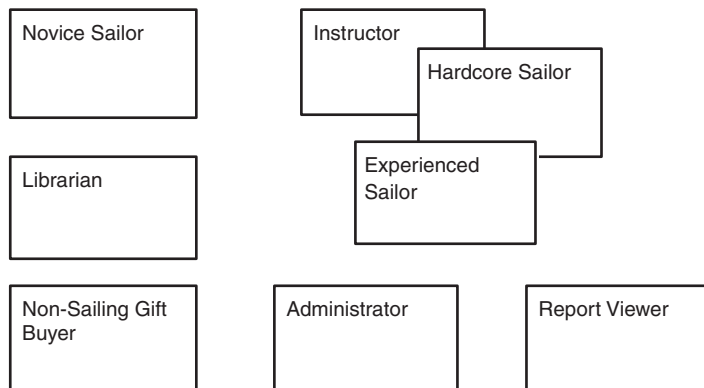


Figure 17.2 *The roles after consolidation and initial discussion.*

Role Modeling

Next, the team considers each role and adds detail to the role cards. The details will vary based on the domain and the type of software but good, general factors to consider include:

- The frequency with which the user will use the software.
- The user's level of expertise with the domain.
- The user's general level of proficiency with computers and software.
- The user's level of proficiency with the software being developed.
- The user's general goal for using the software. Some users are after convenience, others favor a rich experience, and so on.

The group discusses these issues for each role card. They update the user role cards as follows:

Novice Sailor: Experienced web shopper. Expected to make 6 purchases during first 3 months of sailing. Is sometimes referred to a specific title; other times needs help selecting the right book. Wants more help in selecting appropriate books (good content written at the appropriate level) than she gets in a physical bookstore.

Instructor: Expected to use the website frequently, often once a week. Through the company's telephone sales group, an Instructor frequently places similar orders (for example, 20 copies of the same book). Proficient with the website but usually somewhat nervous around computers. Interested in getting the best prices. Not interested in reviews or other "frills."

Hard Core Sailor: Generally inexperienced with computers. A large purchaser of items from the company's catalog but not a large purchaser of books. Buys lots of additional equipment from us. Usually knows exactly what he's looking for. Doesn't want to feel stupid while trying to use the site.

Experienced Sailor: Proficient with computers. Expected to order once or twice per quarter, perhaps more often during the summer. Knowledgeable about sailing but usually only for local regions. Very interested in what other sailors say are the best products and the best places to sail.

Non-Sailing Gift Buyer: Usually proficient with computers (or would not chose to purchase a gift online). Not a sailor and will have passing familiarity at best with sailing terms. Will usually be after a very specific book but may be looking for a book on a given topic.

Librarian: Proficient with computers. Knows exactly what she is looking for and prefers to order by ISBN rather than author or even title. Not particularly interested in frills such as gift wrapping or tracking shipments. Will generally place a small number of orders per year but each order will be for more books than a typical individual order.

Administrator: Highly proficient with computers. Has at least a passing familiarity with sailing. Accesses the back-end of the system daily as part of her job. Interested in quickly learning the software but will want advanced user shortcuts later.

Report Viewer: Moderate proficiency with computers, mostly with business programs such as spreadsheets and word processors. Interested in highly detailed data on how the system is working, what visitors are buying or not buying, and how they are navigating or searching the site. Very willing to trade speed for power and depth.

Adding Personas

It is sometimes worth spending a few minutes adding a persona to the work done thus far. The team asks Lori which of these user roles must absolutely be satisfied with the new website in order for it to succeed. She says that Hardcore Sailors are important because of their longevity as customers. But, even though they sail frequently, they are not large purchasers of books. On the other hand, the large population of Experienced Sailors is important and that group buys a significant number of books. Lori adds that perhaps the most important role to satisfy is the Instructor. Instructors can be responsible for the sale of hundreds of books throughout the year. In fact, she continues, with the new website she'd like to investigate ways of eventually offering financial incentives to Instructors who refer their students to the site.

With this information in mind the team decides to develop two personas. The first persona is Teresa. Teresa has been sailing for four years. She is the CEO of a publicly-traded biotech company and is completely comfortable ordering online. Teresa sails mainly during the summer so she'll only use the site during spring or summer, when preparing for a cruise. She's very busy and is interested in using our site to save time and to find books she hasn't seen before. Teresa is married to Tom, who doesn't sail himself but has accompanied Teresa on on two cruises through the Mediterranean.

The second persona is Captain Ron. Captain Ron has been sailing for 40 years and runs a sailing school out of San Diego. He retired from teaching high school five years ago and has been a sailing instructor ever since. He's been a loyal catalog customer for ten years. He's still a little intimidated by the computer in his office but he's intrigued enough by ordering on the web that we expect him to give it a try.

A Caveat about Teresa and Captain Ron

It's debatable whether it is worth adding personas to this system. Only add a persona if doing so helps your team think through stories for a critical-to-satisfy user of your system. For the South Coast Nautical Supplies system described in these chapters, it's probably not worth the extra effort.

However, since personas can be a valuable addition to your toolbox, I have included Teresa and Captain Ron in order to provide a more complete example.

